

Kuhl's flying gecko

Ptychozoon kuhli

- ↔ 7–8 in (18–20 cm)
- 📍 SE. Asia
- ⊗ Not known

Several species of so-called flying geckos have elaborate webbing of skin between their digits and along their body, which serve to help these tree-dwelling lizards glide from perch to perch. This species is widespread in rainforests of Southeast Asia and is colored for effective camouflage against the background of foliage and tree bark. It usually rests head-down on a tree trunk, in readiness to jump.

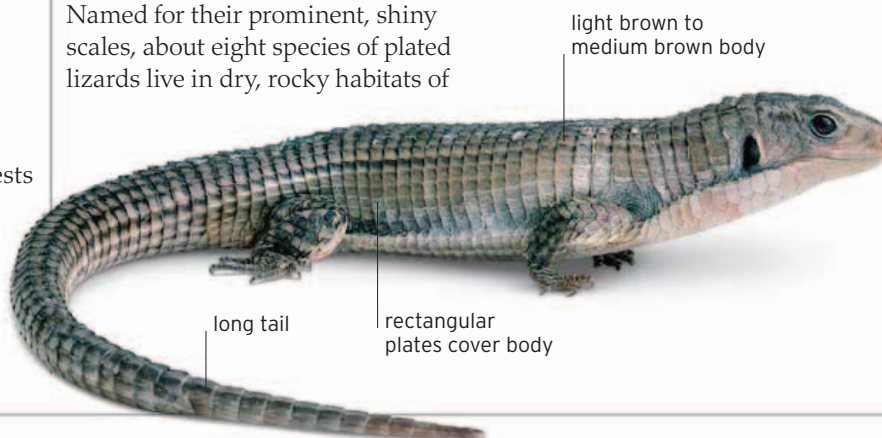
Rough-scaled plated lizard

Broadleysaurus major

- ↔ 16–19 in (40–48 cm)
- 📍 C., E., and Southern Africa
- ⊗ Not known

Named for their prominent, shiny scales, about eight species of plated lizards live in dry, rocky habitats of

Africa. This species eats leaves, fruit, and insects. Its armorlike skin protects it from predators—and keeps it wedged in rocky crevices when danger threatens. Males are highly territorial and flaunt a pink throat during the breeding season.



Sand lizard

Lacerta agilis

- ↔ 7–9 in (18–22 cm)
- 📍 Europe to C. Asia
- ⊗ Common

In the northern part of its range, this lizard is confined to coastal sand dunes and sandy heaths, but further south it is more widespread in open country and yards; here, it is called the “agile lizard.” There is considerable geographic variation in color, but males are always more vivid in the breeding season. The sand lizard is active by day, feeding on small insects and spiders, and—like related species—may shed its tail if attacked by predators.

Viviparous lizard

Zootoca vivipara

- ↔ 4–5 in (10–13 cm)
- 📍 Europe to C. and E. Asia (including Japan)
- ⊗ Common

This species belongs to an Old World family of fast-running, so-called lacertid lizards. It is the only member of this family to have populations that give birth to live young; it ranges farther north than any other species of lizard—where it is too cold for eggs to develop properly. Close to the Arctic Circle, it survives the coldest periods in underground hibernation.

African fire skink

Lepidothryis fernandi

- ↔ 9–15 in (23–38 cm)
- 📍 W. and C. Africa
- ⊗ Not known

The bright stripe of orange-red on its flank gives this African lizard its name. It belongs to a group of skinks characterized by a similar pattern. Like most other skinks, this is a slender-bodied, shiny-scaled lizard with small limbs. It lives among leaf litter on the ground and is active at twilight. It hunts for insect prey among tree roots in woodland, but may also venture into open grassland.

Eyed skink

Chalcides ocellatus

- ↔ 12 in (30 cm)
- 📍 S. Europe, N. and NE. Africa, W. Asia
- ⊗ Not known

A native of dry Mediterranean scrub, this short-limbed skink is one of many species called “sand-swimming” skinks. In loose sand, it moves swiftly forward by undulating its body, like a snake. Above ground, it can use its feet for walking, but some related sand-swimmers lack limbs altogether. It is named for the pattern of eyelike spots that occur on its body.

Blue-tongued skink

Tiliqua scincoides

- ↔ 18–20 in (45–50 cm)
- 📍 N., E., and SE. Australia
- ⊗ Not known

Unlike its smaller, nimble insect-eating cousins, this heavy-bodied, slow-moving skink mainly eats flowers, fruit, and berries, but may supplement this diet with small animals. In its native land, it is often seen basking on roads, where a flash of its bright blue tongue may help to deter predators. Like other giant skinks of the Australasian region, it gives birth to live young—after a 5-month gestation period.

Emerald tree skink

Lamprolepis smaragdina

- ↔ 7–10 in (18–25 cm)
- 📍 SE. Asia, New Guinea, Pacific islands
- ⊗ Not known

This agile, tree-living skink climbs well and hunts for insects, flowers, and fruit. The species occurs on many islands throughout archipelagos of Southeast Asia and

Australasia. Like other tree-living lizards, its dispersal through the region is perhaps facilitated by rafting over water on “islands” of floating vegetation.



Slow worm

Anguis fragilis

- ↔ 12–20 in (30–50 cm)
- 📍 Europe to W. Asia, NW. Africa
- ⊗ Not known

One of several legless lizards, the slow worm is often mistaken for a snake—but its eyelids serve to distinguish it as a true lizard. Its scientific name, *fragilis*, refers to its habit of shedding its tail when attacked. A new tail grows slowly, and so many of these lizards have a truncated appearance. Slow worms have a long lifespan, but they hibernate for nearly half the year in the coldest parts of their range.

Komodo dragon

Varanus komodoensis

- ↔ 7–10 ft (2–3 m)
- 📍 Indonesia (Komodo, Rinca, Padar, W. Flores)
- ⊗ Vulnerable

The world's largest lizard is a powerful, clawed flesh eater, perfectly suited as the top predator on its native island habitat—where it preys on animals as big as deer. This giant monitor lizard delivers a savage bite with sharp teeth. Venom in its saliva, along with possible bacterial infections, means that the wound festers, eventually disabling the prey so the dragon can make an easier kill.